SHAHRAM AJLOO

Project Manager · Automation service, retrofit and upgrade projects

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Application: Project Manager, Automation Service Projects

To Nicolai Heilskov, Head of Project Management in Service

A retrofit on a plant that is still running is a different discipline from a greenfield project. The customer is not buying new equipment — he is buying the shortest possible interruption to production, a control system that behaves exactly as the operators expect afterwards, and a supplier who knows which work has to happen inside the shutdown window and which can be done before it. Service projects are won on that sequencing, and they are lost on the commercial detail: a change nobody priced, a claim nobody documented, an aftermarket opportunity nobody followed up. That is the job I am applying for.

Tender through handover is the part of the lifecycle I know best. I have taken scopes from a requirement document to a priced, planned and resourced project, executed it in a live production environment, and closed it with documented acceptance — over **37 parallel projects** at **Novo Nordisk**, with **FAT/SAT and IQ/OQ/PQ** as the gates, change control between them, and **monthly reporting of progress, cost and risk** to management and the client organisation. The portfolio closed with **zero critical findings** at handover. That result came from doing the tender and planning work properly: interfaces specified, assumptions written down, acceptance criteria agreed before anyone started welding.

Automation and OT are my technical home. For five years I was operations and maintenance manager at **Lynetten, a utility plant under Biofos** in the Copenhagen area, running a critical site in **24/7 operation** with **SRO/SCADA** control, pumping stations, blowers, ventilation, transformers and switchgear. I was the customer side of retrofits before I was the supplier side: deciding what could be replaced, in which shutdown window, with which fallback, and what the operators had to be trained in before the change went live. Energy management and load optimisation across the plant delivered **over 40 % lower consumption**, measured. When I say I can hold a technical conversation with an engineering team about a control system upgrade, it is because I have been the one who had to accept the result.

Commercial control is where I add margin rather than just report on it. I run my own electrical contracting company with **full P&L** — pricing, contract terms, response commitments, invoicing and payment risk. I have negotiated change orders on work that was already in progress, taken the conversation when a customer wanted more for the same price, and priced the risk of a response-time commitment before signing it. Changes get priced and agreed before they are executed; claims get documented while the evidence is still on site, not reconstructed three months later.

Service is a portfolio, not a series of one-off jobs. In my own company the recurring revenue comes from service agreements and the follow-on work that a well-run service visit uncovers — the same logic as ABB's aftermarket: a retrofit is the entry point, and the value is in the upgrades, the spares and the service contract that follow. I have built that pipeline myself, and I know which of my customers were worth a follow-up call and which were not.

Teams and stakeholders across sites. I led **14 people at Ventek-Air** across **11 concurrent projects**, with daily prioritisation when a machine or a person dropped out, and I have coordinated customer organisations, consultants, suppliers and authorities at Novo Nordisk. Remote management is ordinary in that environment: the project lives in the plan, the reporting and the escalation rhythm, not in who is in the same building. I also work in Danish and English daily, with **SAP ERP, CMMS, Power BI, Excel/Power Query and Python** as the toolset behind plans, cost control and forecasting.

On compliance I am comfortable being audited. Quality, HSE and information requirements are not paperwork that follows the project — they are constraints the plan has to respect. I have worked in a GMP/FDA/EMA validated environment where documentation was the evidence that work had been done, and I have carried the HSE responsibility on a 24/7 industrial site: permits, safe systems of work, near-miss follow-up and the discipline of stopping a job that is not safe. In an automation service context I treat cybersecurity requirements the same way — access, segmentation and change control agreed before the engineer connects.

I am based in Copenhagen, with **Ballerup** as my natural base and willingness to work from Middelfart or Esbjerg when the projects are there; I have a car and drive across Denmark as a matter of course, and I am available at short notice. I would welcome the chance to discuss which retrofit and service portfolios ABB is running in Denmark right now, and where delivery pressure is highest.

Yours sincerely

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PROFILE

Technical project manager with 20+ years in **automation, control systems and critical industrial plant — authorised engineer (LV/MV/HV)** with a B.Tech in technology and operations management. Led **37 capital projects** with 25 specialists at **Novo Nordisk**: tender and requirements, planning and resourcing, **FAT/SAT and IQ/OQ/PQ**, change control, commissioning and handover, with **monthly progress, cost and risk reporting** and **zero critical findings** at completion. Five years as operations and maintenance manager at **Lynetten (Biofos)** on a **24/7 plant with SRO/SCADA**, pumping stations, transformers and switchgear — **over 40 % lower energy consumption** through load optimisation. Runs an electrical contracting business with **full P&L**: tenders, contracts, change orders, claims, service agreements and aftermarket. Works in Danish and English; **SAP ERP, CMMS, Power BI, Excel/Power Query, Python**.

AUTOMATION, RETROFIT AND SERVICE DELIVERY

- **Retrofit and upgrade in live plant:** Replacement and upgrade of pumps, blowers, ventilation, transformers and switchgear in 24/7 operation: shutdown windows, fallback, operator training and acceptance — sequenced so production kept running.
- **Tender to handover:** Scope and requirement documents converted into priced, planned and resourced projects; FAT/SAT and IQ/OQ/PQ as gates; change control between them; handover documentation signed on both sides.
- **OT, control systems and data:** SRO/SCADA in daily operation: alarms, regulation, fault finding and version changes; PLC-adjacent electrical control, instrumentation and the data path from plant to reporting.
- **Financials and forecasting:** Project budgets, cost control and monthly forecast versus actual; earned value and commitment tracking; dashboards and cost models built in Power BI, Excel/Power Query and Python.
- **Commercial and contractual:** Full P&L in own company: tender pricing, contract terms, response commitments, change orders, claims and payment risk — with the documentation trail kept while the work is on site.
- **Customer and aftermarket:** Service agreements, recurring visits and follow-on work identified from the service visit; upsell built on the customer's actual constraint rather than a product catalogue.

EXPERIENCE

Owner / Technical Director — ELOHVAC ApS · Copenhagen · May 2023–present

Scope: 5 electricians and 3 apprentices · full P&L · authorised engineer · LV/MV/HV service and retrofit work

- **Service projects, contracts and margin:** Tender pricing, contract terms, change orders and payment risk on electrical service and retrofit work; service agreements and follow-on upgrades; own Python and Claude tooling for costing, checklists and KPI reporting with over 40 % productivity gain.

Senior Commissioning Engineer / Project Manager, Electrical Systems — Novo Nordisk A/S · Kalundborg/Bagsværd, Denmark · Nov 2022–Jul 2024

Scope: 37 parallel capital projects · 25 specialists · DKK 2–10m each · GMP/FDA/EMA validated environment

- **Tender to handover in a validated plant:** Requirements and design review, FAT/SAT, IQ/OQ/PQ, change control and commissioning for electrical and control systems; monthly progress, cost and risk reporting to management and client; zero critical findings at handover.

Project and Workshop Manager — Ventek-Air · Copenhagen · Jan 2022–Nov 2022

Scope: 14 employees · 11 concurrent projects · DKK 2–10m per project

- **Multi-site delivery and recovery:** Daily board meeting, capacity and bottleneck analysis, same-day re-prioritisation; standardised work packages and handover documentation; teams and subcontractors managed across sites.

Operations and Maintenance Manager — Lynetten under Biofos · Copenhagen · Aug 2017–Jan 2022

Scope: Critical utility plant in 24/7 operation · SRO/SCADA · pumping, ventilation, transformers, switchgear

- **Owner of the plant the retrofits happened in:** Criticality assessment, replacement plans, spares and contractors; shutdown planning and fallback; HSE responsibility including permits, safe systems of work and near-miss follow-up; energy and load optimisation with over 40 % lower consumption.

Electromechanical Technician / Production Team Leader — ARJ Engineering · Tehran · Dec 2003–Mar 2010

Scope: 12 mechanics and technicians · machine workshop · industrial equipment

- **Technical delivery and team leadership:** Fault finding and root-cause analysis on industrial equipment; shift planning, training and performance follow-up for 12 technicians.

EDUCATION AND AUTHORISATION

B.Tech, Technology and Operations Management; Mechanical Engineering · Copenhagen School of Marine and Mechanical Engineering · 2017–2022 · GPA 7.6/12

Authorised Engineer (el-autorisation), LV/MV/HV · Danish Safety Technology Authority · May 2023

Electrical and Mechanical Design, Electrical Engineering · Tehran Technical University · 2000–2003 · EQF 6

Refrigeration and Ventilation Technology • STCW · Mercantec 2021 · Danish Maritime Authority 2021

LANGUAGES, PRACTICALITIES AND REFERENCES

Danish: native · English: professional, written and spoken, including technical and commercial negotiation · Persian: native · Based in Copenhagen; Ballerup, Middelfart and Esbjerg all workable, with travel across Denmark and occasional Nordic travel · Driving licence B and own car · Home working days as agreed · Available at short notice · References on request.

THE FIRST 90 DAYS — PROJECTS, MARGIN AND AFTERMARKET

Phase	What happens, and how it is measured
Week 1–2	Meet the project management colleagues, the engineering and service teams and the customers behind the three most active retrofits; read the contracts, the change logs and the last two project reviews; find out where the delivery pressure actually sits.
Day 30	Each live project has a plan built from the shutdown window backwards, a forecast against budget and a named owner per interface; the open change orders are priced and either accepted by the customer or closed; escalation rhythm agreed with the Head of Project Management.
Day 60	Cost control moved from monthly surprise to weekly visibility — commitments, hours and forecast at completion visible on a dashboard rather than reconstructed at month end; aftermarket follow-up agreed for every completed service visit.
Day 90	Projects delivering to plan with variance visible early; claims documented while the evidence is fresh; a short list of upgrade opportunities generated from service findings and handed to sales with a price and a technical rationale.

THE SHUTDOWN WINDOW IS THE WHOLE PROJECT

In a service retrofit, the plan is not the list of tasks — it is the sequence that fits inside the window the plant can be down. That means deciding weeks in advance what is pre-assembled, what is tested offline, what can be commissioned in parallel and what has to be done live; agreeing the fallback with the operations team; and having the documentation ready so acceptance does not consume the remaining hours. I have planned and worked those windows from both sides, and the discipline is the same: nothing on the critical path that has not been proven somewhere else first.

CHANGE ORDERS ARE WON IN THE FIRST WEEK, NOT THE LAST

Most commercial disputes in retrofit work are not arguments about money; they are arguments about evidence. The scope change was visible on site for three weeks before anyone wrote it down, and by the time it became a claim, the photographs, the site instruction and the hours were gone. I run projects so that the change is priced and accepted while the crew is still standing next to it — which keeps the relationship intact and the margin where it belongs.

SERVICE IS WHERE THE NEXT PROJECT COMES FROM

A service visit is the cheapest sales meeting a company will ever have, if anyone captures what it revealed: an obsolete drive, a spares shortage, a control system two versions behind. I have built that loop in my own business, and it is the same loop ABB runs at scale — the difference is discipline in recording it and following up while the finding is still fresh.

I HAVE BEEN THE CUSTOMER IN A RETROFIT

At Lynetten I was the operations manager who had to accept a supplier's retrofit — which means I know what a customer actually wants from the project manager opposite him: no surprises in the shutdown window, an honest answer about what will not be finished, a fallback that works if the new system does not, and a handover pack the night shift can use at 03:00 without calling anyone. That perspective changes how I write a plan and how I price a risk. A supplier who says "we will manage" gets no second shutdown window.

WHAT THE ROLE REQUIRES — WHAT I HAVE DELIVERED

Requirement in the posting	Evidence
Service, retrofit and upgrade projects from tender to final delivery	Electrical and control retrofits in 24/7 plant: tender pricing, shutdown sequencing, fallback, acceptance; 37 projects from requirement to signed handover at Novo Nordisk.
Project planning, scheduling, resource plans and execution	Plans built from dependencies and shutdown windows; 11 concurrent projects resourced and re-prioritised daily at Ventek-Air; 25 specialists scheduled across 37 projects.
Customer relationships and acting as trusted advisor	Primary contact for clients in own company from quote to final invoice; bygherre, consultants and authorities coordinated in a validated plant environment.
Commercial risks, project changes, claims and recovery actions	Change orders priced before execution, claims documented while evidence is on site; recovery plans with owners, dates and a commercial consequence.
Project financials: forecasting, cost control and value optimization	Budgets, monthly forecast versus actual and commitment tracking on 37 projects; full P&L in own company; cost models and dashboards in Power BI, Excel/Power Query and Python.
Aftermarket opportunities and upselling	Service agreements, recurring visits and follow-on upgrades built into the revenue of own company; upsell driven by the customer's operating constraint.
Contract management and change management	Contract terms, response commitments and payment risk negotiated and held; change control applied between FAT/SAT and IQ/OQ/PQ gates and documented at handover.
Compliance with quality, cybersecurity and HSE requirements	GMP/FDA/EMA validated environment where documentation proved the work; HSE responsibility on a 24/7 site — permits, safe systems of work, near-miss follow-up; access and change control agreed before connection.
4–7 years of project management in technical, industrial or automation environments	Project management since 2010 and formally from 2017: operations and maintenance leadership, 37 capital projects, 11 concurrent construction projects, and own company project portfolio since 2023.
Leading project teams and driving delivery to milestones, including remote management	25 specialists and 14 staff led across sites; delivery driven on milestone, reporting pack and escalation rhythm rather than proximity; 12 technicians led at ARJ.
Customers and cross-functional stakeholders in complex project environments	Client organisations, consultants, suppliers, authorities and internal engineering functions aligned through 37 projects and a 24/7 operating organisation.
Project planning, budgeting and execution methodologies	Stage-gate delivery with acceptance gates (FAT/SAT, IQ/OQ/PQ), RAID and monthly reporting; budgeting and forecasting in SAP ERP and Excel/Power Query.
Tender phase through commissioning and handover	Requirement documents and tenders turned into priced projects, then executed and commissioned — closure with documented acceptance and zero critical findings.
Automation, OT or industrial control systems, preferably energy, process, power or offshore	SRO/SCADA, instrumentation and electrical control on a critical utility plant in 24/7 operation; energy and load optimisation with over 40 % measured reduction.
Excellent communication in Danish and English; Azure DevOps, Microsoft Project or similar	Danish native and English professional, including technical and commercial negotiation; planning data, cost control and dashboards in SAP ERP, CMMS, Power BI, Excel/Power Query and Python.
PMP, PRINCE2, IPMA or comparable certification considered an advantage	Stage-gate governance practised to that standard: defined gates, acceptance criteria, change control, RAID, monthly forecast and handover evidence across 37 projects.

THE PLAN HAS TO SURVIVE CONTACT WITH THE PLANT

Every retrofit plan meets reality on day one: a cable route nobody surveyed, an obsolete card with a delivery time in weeks, an operator who was not in the design review and does not recognise the screen. The project manager cannot prevent that; he can make sure it is discovered early, costed quickly and decided by someone with the authority to decide. That is why I run short cycles with the engineering team and the customer in the same room — and why I write the decision down on the day it is taken.

CYBERSECURITY IS A DELIVERY CONSTRAINT, NOT A CHECKBOX

An automation retrofit almost always touches a network, and the fastest way to lose a go-live is to discover at commissioning that the segmentation, the accounts or the remote access were never agreed. I treat those requirements as part of the plan from the tender: what has to be in place before the engineer connects, who approves it on the customer side, and what the fallback is when it is delayed. It is the same discipline as a permit to work — unglamorous, and the reason the job finishes on time.